

GRIDLINE STUDIO — BUSINESS PLAN

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1\ OVERVIEW

Gridline Studio is a graphic design and visual branding studio serving small businesses in small towns across the United States. The studio offers full rebranding packages — logo design, color/typography systems, social media templates, signage and menu concepts, and branded visual mockups — at a price point and turnaround that fits a small business budget.

A second division, Gridline Motorsports, applies the same design capability to NASCAR/ARCA livery and racing team branding. This division is a planned future addition, to be launched once the small business side has a consistent flow of client work (see Section 9).

Founder currently works full-time elsewhere; Gridline Studio operates as a part-time build, roughly 10-15 hours per week.

2\ THE PROBLEM

Small businesses in small and mid-sized towns are stuck between two bad options:

Hiring a full marketing/design agency, which is typically priced for corporate budgets and out of reach for a local bakery, bistro, or shop.

Doing it themselves, which usually means inconsistent branding pieced together over years — a logo from one era, a sign from another, social posts with no shared visual identity. The result is a business that may have great products or service, but doesn't look trustworthy or current at first glance.

This gap is the opportunity: professional-quality rebranding, priced and scoped for a small business, not a corporate client.

3\ WHAT WE OFFER

Gridline Studio's positioning is full rebranding packages, not piecemeal design tasks. Clients buy an outcome — "your business looks cohesive and current" — not a list of deliverables.

Core package components (bundled, not sold individually by default):

- \- Logo design and brand mark
- \- Color palette and typography system
- \- Social media templates and content direction
- \- Signage / menu board concepts

- \- Branded mockups (packaging, cups, print materials, storefront/exterior concept visuals)
- \- Branding guide PDF (see Section 6 for tier-by-tier contents)
- \- Website creation (top tier only — see Section 6)

Important scope boundary: Gridline Studio operates on the graphic design side only. This includes visual concept renders showing how branding and signage could look applied to an existing space — it does not include interior remodeling, construction specification, layout changes, or furniture/material sourcing. Concept visuals are explicitly framed as design ideation, not renovation or architectural plans.

4\ TARGET MARKET

Primary target: small businesses in small towns across the United States — restaurants, cafes, juice bars, retail shops, gyms, and similar storefronts with weak or inconsistent branding but a genuine, sellable identity underneath.

Strong-fit signals to look for when identifying prospects:

- \- Business has real character or a good product, but visual presentation doesn't reflect it
- \- Mismatched or dated signage, menus, or social presence
- \- No consistent logo, or a logo that hasn't been updated in years
- \- Local/independent ownership (faster decision-making than a chain or franchise)

Remote recon protocol: all prospect research is conducted remotely — no in-person site visits. Most productive sequence: web search (hours/menu/review sentiment) → image search on business name \+ city → image search on street address. Skip Facebook and JS-rendered ordering pages (Clover, etc.) — they block automated fetching and return empty shells.

5\ PRICING STRUCTURE

Package-based pricing, not hourly. Hourly billing creates budget anxiety for small business owners who can't predict total cost; a flat package price removes that friction.

Package range: \$750 \- \$5,000+, scaled by scope:

- \- Smaller packages (\~\$750-1,500): logo refresh, color/type system, basic social templates
- \- Mid-tier packages (\~\$1,500-3,000): full identity system plus signage/menu concepts and branded mockups
- \- Larger packages (\$3,000-5,000+): full rebrand including storefront concept visuals, multi-platform social content, print collateral, and a simple website

NOTE: Exact tiers and inclusions to be finalized after Portfolio Project 1 is complete and pricing can be sanity-checked against real time investment (see Time Log).

Founding client pricing: first 1-2 real clients will receive slightly discounted "founding client"

pricing in exchange for case studies and testimonials, then transition to full target pricing.

6\ STANDARD DELIVERABLES BY PACKAGE TIER

This section defines a reusable deliverables template, scaled by tier, so every proposal and portfolio project references the same baseline instead of a one-off list. Counts are a starting draft — adjust once Panacea Junkiez is costed out against actual time spent (see Time Log).

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TIER 1 — LOGO REFRESH (\~\$750-1,500)

- \- Primary logo: 1 mark, 2 color variations (full color \+ single-color/black)
- \- Color palette: 3-5 core colors with hex/CMYK values
- \- Typography system: 2 fonts (primary \+ secondary), usage notes
- \- Social media templates: 3-5 templates (1 platform, e.g. Instagram)
- \- Branding guide PDF (condensed, 2-4 pages): logo lockups \+ clear space/minimum size, color values, font names \+ pairing example
- \- 1 round of revisions

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TIER 2 — FULL IDENTITY SYSTEM (\~\$1,500-3,000)

Everything in Tier 1, plus:

- \- Logo suite: primary mark \+ icon/monogram \+ watermark (3 total marks, each in color \+ single-color)
- \- Signage / menu concept: 1-2 concepts
- \- Branded mockups: 4-6 (e.g. packaging, cups, print materials, apparel)
- \- Social media templates: expanded to 6-8, across 2 platforms
- \- Branding guide PDF (full, 8-12 pages): logo suite \+ usage rules (do's/don'ts), full color system, full type system with hierarchy examples, mockup gallery, voice/tone notes
- \- 2 rounds of revisions

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TIER 3 — FULL REBRAND \+ WEBSITE (\$3,000-5,000+)

Everything in Tier 2, plus:

- \- Product renders: 2
- \- Environment / lifestyle renders: 2
- \- Storefront/exterior concept visual: 1-2
- \- Multi-platform social content: expanded template set across 3+ platforms, plus a content

direction one-pager

- \- Print collateral: expanded (menu, signage set, business cards, etc. — scoped per project)
- \- Website creation: simple site, up to 5 pages (e.g. Home, Menu/Services, About, Gallery, Contact), built on a low-cost platform (Squarespace, Framer, or similar), using assets from the brand system
- \- Branding guide PDF (comprehensive, 15+ pages): full logo suite \+ usage rules, complete color/type system, mockup gallery, render gallery, website style notes, before/after case study spread
- \- 3 rounds of revisions

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Note: the branding guide PDF is the single reference document a client receives at handoff, showing every deliverable in one place (logo variations, colors, fonts, mockups, renders as applicable). It scales in depth by tier rather than being a separate add-on.

Portfolio project tier assignments:

- \- Panacea Junkiez — Tier 1
- \- Ashworth — Tier 2
- \- K1 Fitness — Tier 3, minus website

7. PORTFOLIO STRATEGY

Target: 3 portfolio projects before starting outreach. After the initial 3, additional portfolio-building should come from paid client work rather than more spec work.

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PORTFOLIO PROJECT 1 — Panacea Junkiez (Kinston, NC)

Type: Real business, genuine spec pitch to owner — not portfolio-only.

Status: Remote recon complete. Brand direction locked. 18-tile logo calibration board produced and reviewed. Primary logo has been created. Logo file currently lives on a separate local computer — not yet transferred/accessible from this workspace. Deliverable tier: Tier 1 (see Section 6). Next step: retrieve logo file, then build out remaining Tier 1 deliverables.

Business: Panacea Junkiez, Kinston, NC. Organic smoothies, salads, teas, detox drinks, healthy shots. Open Mon–Fri 4–7pm only — small-footprint, likely sole-operator, personality-driven. Modest existing visual identity with clear room for upgrade. Mixed-positive local reputation.

Brand direction:

- \- Palette: Saturated yellow/coral/green

\- Style: Polished-but-playful, agency-grade execution — closer to The Blendery and Papaya than DIY/zine

\- Lettering: Exploring loose hand-script vs. chunky bouncy display type before committing

\- Central design opportunity: the name's internal tension ("Panacea" \= wellness-coded / "Junkiez" \= scrappy). Direction C (script "Panacea" \+ bold stamp "Junkiez") may resolve this by giving each word its own voice.

Logo calibration board directions:

\- Direction A: Loose script throughout

\- Direction B: Chunky bouncy display throughout

\- Direction C: Mixed — script "Panacea" \+ bold stamp "Junkiez"

Style references: The Blendery, Papaya, Komama

Next steps:

- 1\.. Retrieve logo file from separate computer
- 2\.. Build out remaining Tier 1 deliverables (see Section 6)
- 3\.. Assemble condensed branding guide PDF

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PORTFOLIO PROJECT 2 — Ashworth (Fictional)

Type: Fictional brand — full creative control, no IP/disclaimer concerns.

Status: All visual direction locked. Entering mockup phase. Two open decisions to resolve before sketching.

Brand concept: Minimalist, premium hometown apparel brand celebrating a fictional rust belt Midwest town built around rail car and rail infrastructure manufacturing — peaked early-to-mid 20th century, classic post-industrial decline arc. Hometown pride positioning gives the brand emotional weight that outlasted the industry itself.

Visual direction:

\- Primary icon: Rail trestle/bridge as simplified geometric truss silhouette

\- Secondary/monogram mark: "A" letterform constructed from bridge truss geometry — for small-scale applications (woven labels, embossed patches, social avatars). Key constraint: truss geometry must function simultaneously as letter AND structure — not an A with decorative lines added. Failure mode is "letter with decoration" rather than a single integrated form.

\- Palette: Muted rust/brick \+ cream/off-white (material logic: oxidized rail iron)

\- Typography: Tracked-out caps sans for primary wordmark; serif or softer sans as secondary

\- Positioning: Minimalist, premium DTC — Everlane/Buck Mason/ALD quiet register

Open decisions to resolve before sketching:

- 1\ Icon literalism level (abstract truss pattern vs. simplified recognizable trestle silhouette)
- 2\ Primary lockup structure (icon \+ wordmark combined vs. wordmark-only primary with icon reserved for secondary use)

Sequencing note: Wordmark and A-mark must be locked before any derivative deliverables are produced.

Deliverable tier: Tier 2 (see Section 6).

Deliverables:

- 1\ Primary wordmark \+ trestle icon
- 2\ A-truss monogram mark
- 3\ Tee and hoodie mockups
- 4\ Hang tags
- 5\ Flagship store concept shot
- 6\ Social media post
- 7\ Before/after case study compilation
- 8\ Branding guide PDF (full)

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PORTFOLIO PROJECT 3 — K1 Fitness (Walnut Ridge, AR)

Type: Real business, genuine spec pitch to owner — not portfolio-only.

Status: Business selected. Concept work not yet started.

Business: K1 Fitness Center, 217 West Elm St, Walnut Ridge, AR 72476\ Independently owned 24-hour gym in a small Arkansas town (\~4,500 people). 100% recommended across 27 reviews. Budget-priced, strong community reputation, minimal existing branding.

Next steps when starting this project:

- 1\ Remote recon (web search \+ image search on business name and street address)
- 2\ Concept anchor
- 3\ Moodboard
- 4\ Logo direction

Deliverable tier: Tier 3, minus website (see Section 6). Full deliverable set — logo suite, product/environment renders, storefront concept, expanded print collateral, comprehensive branding guide PDF — but no website build for this project.

Deliverables (exact scope TBD after concept anchor is set):

- \- Logo suite (primary \+ icon/monogram \+ watermark)
- \- Color palette \+ typography

- \- Branded mockups (signage, membership card, apparel)
- \- Product renders (2) \+ environment/lifestyle renders (2)
- \- Storefront/exterior concept visual
- \- Social media templates (multi-platform)
- \- Before/after case study compilation
- \- Branding guide PDF (comprehensive)
- \- No website (excluded from this project's scope)

8\ CLIENT ACQUISITION / OUTREACH

Sequence: email first, followed by physical mail for non-responders.

Expectations: cold outreach response rates to small businesses are typically low (low single digits). Consistent volume matters more than any single message. Portfolio is the core asset — tailor to the prospect's business category where possible.

Open items to define before outreach begins:

- \- Outreach list building process
- \- Email template(s) and mail piece design
- \- Follow-up cadence and number of touches before moving on

9\ FUTURE: GRIDLINE MOTORSPORTS (LIVERY DIVISION)

A second division applying Gridline's design capability to NASCAR/ARCA livery and racing team branding. An existing process document covers predesign, design, presentation, and marketing phases.

Launch condition: activated only once the small business rebranding side has consistent client flow. The two divisions are intentionally sequenced to avoid splitting limited part-time hours across two unproven service lines at once.

10\ OPERATIONS

Current setup:

- \- Email: gridlinestudioa@gmail.com (active)
- \- Google Drive: Gridline Studio folder (active — business plan and time log saved here)
- \- Payment method: TBD (PayPal, Venmo Business, or bank transfer — pick one)
- \- Invoice template: TBD (one page: name/logo, client name, project description, price, due date, payment instructions)
- \- Client contract: TBD (at minimum a simple scope-of-work email confirmation before work begins)

To formalize later, once there's consistent paid work:

- \- Business entity / LLC
- \- Formal contracts
- \- Accounting/bookkeeping tool
- \- Full portfolio website

11\ OPEN QUESTIONS / NEXT DECISIONS

- \- Retrieve Panacea Junkiez logo file from separate computer
- \- Confirm Panacea Junkiez deliverable tier and complete remaining assets
- \- Resolve two open Ashworth decisions (icon literalism, lockup structure) before beginning sketch work
- \- Start K1 Fitness concept work (remote recon first)
- \- Complete all three portfolio projects before beginning outreach
- \- Set up payment method
- \- Create simple invoice template
- \- Finalize exact package tiers and inclusions (Section 6) after Project 1 is costed out against time log
- \- Build outreach list and draft email \+ mail templates
- \- Decide on business entity formation timing
- \- Define the consistent-work threshold that triggers launching the Motorsports division
- \- Decide on website platform for Tier 3 (Squarespace vs. Framer vs. other) and confirm it fits within the part-time time budget